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INTERNATIONAL

Peaceful Palestine Solidarity Demo in New Delhi Runs Into Rough Weather

A press note from the civil society coalition — including students, academics, economist Jean Drèze, and former IAS officer Harsh Mander — that organised a silent Palestine solidarity demonstration at Delhi's Nehru Place on 29th July 2025, and encountered mob violence and police threats for doing so.

BY MOULI SHARMA



The following press note was released by the civil society solidarity group that had organised a silent demonstration against the Indian government's complicity in Israel's genocide in and of occupied Palestine at Delhi's Nehru Place on the 29th of July 2025. The group, consisting various student organisations including AISA, SFI, etc, along with Palestine Advocacy groups such as Indians for Palestine, and civil society members like economist Jean Drèze, automobile worker rights leader Khushiram, former DU Teacher's Association President Nandita Narain, former IAS officer Harsh Mander and many more, faced mob violence and threats of police detention.

The gathering also served to condemn the Indian government's ongoing complicity in Israel's campaign. Over the past two years, more than 50,000 people—mostly civilians—have been killed in Gaza. Thousands more are injured, displaced, starving, and denied medical care. Israel's war has been systematic, deliberate, and documented live. Yet the Indian government has not only remained silent, but actively participated—subsidising defence-sector joint ventures, dispatching Indian workers to replace Palestinian labour in Israel, and repeatedly abstaining from UN resolutions that condemn Israel's crimes.

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Despite the strictly peaceful nature of the demonstration, it was met with hostility from many local onlookers and passers-by. A large and hostile crowd quickly surrounded the protestors. Some individuals from the mob approached protestors and questioned their motives, asking, “Why don’t you raise the Indian flag too?” In an effort to engage peacefully, one demonstrator did raise the Indian flag. However, it was quickly snatched away, and the crowd began chanting “Bharat Mata ki Jai”; some also chanted “Jai Shri Ram.” From that point, the mob’s behaviour became increasingly aggressive.

Water and mud were hurled at protestors from balconies above. Some chanted “Israel Zindabad, Palestine Murdabad,” turning the space into a site of hostility and intimidation. Eyewitness accounts describe rapid escalation and targeted harassment, particularly of Muslim participants and women protestors. One demonstrator shared: “It went really south... A Sanghi crowd formed instantly and began aggressive sloganeering. They cornered our Muslim colleague and started harassing women. I saw men surrounding a female participant and shouting at her.”

“It went really south... A Sanghi crowd formed instantly and began aggressive sloganeering. They cornered our Muslim colleague and started harassing women. I saw men surrounding a female participant and shouting at her.” - A demonstrator at Nehru Place on 19th July 2025.

The police eventually arrived, but rather than addressing the aggression of the right-wing crowd, they demanded permission papers from the protestors. No action was taken against those who had disrupted the event, hurled objects, or threatened participants. This selective enforcement only reinforced what many already know: the right to peaceful assembly and dissent is under severe attack in today’s India—while impunity is often extended to those aligned with majoritarian power.

The choice of Nehru Place as a site was symbolic—an open, public market square frequented by working-class people, students, and office-goers alike. It was meant to reclaim democratic space in a city where protest is now virtually criminalised. Despite everything, the message of the gathering remains clear: There are Indians who stand—and will continue to stand—with the people of Palestine.

Press note by 19th July collective . For further information or interviews, please contact: Anjali (8130580438), Aban (9711155641), Priya (9311548645).

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